



Identifying adjectives

Adverbs such as *very* or *extremely* can be used to exaggerate the state of a subject. These adverbs are sometimes confused with adjectives. A simple way of checking whether a word is an adjective or an adverb is to break down a sentence, pairing each descriptive word in turn with the noun to see if the resulting phrase makes sense.

A **hungry**, **decidedly** **weary** painter

A **hungry** painter



This is an adjective, because the phrase makes sense.

A **decidedly** painter



This is not an adjective, because the phrase doesn't make sense. It is an adverb.

A **weary** painter



This is also an adjective, because the phrase makes sense.

Listing adjectives

If one word is not enough to describe something, use several adjectives. Each adjective should be separated from the next by a comma. If there is a list of adjectives at the end of the clause, the last adjective must be preceded by *and*.

blue, green, and white overalls

Place a comma between adjectives in a list.

The last adjective should follow the word *and*.



• Avoid using two adjectives together that mean the same thing: for example, “the hungry, starving, ravenous tennis player.” This **unnecessary repetition** of the same idea using different words is known as **tautology**.

blue, green, and white overalls
meal because he felt **ravenous**.

Predicate adjectives

Many adjectives can also be placed at the end of a sentence, following a verb. This is known as the predicate position. A verb used in this way is called a linking verb, because it connects a subject with a descriptive word. Common linking verbs include *seem*, *look*, *feel*, *become*, *stay*, and *turn*.

he felt **ravenous**

linking verb

adjective in predicate position

Adjective endings

Many adjectives can be recognized by their endings. Knowing these endings can help to distinguish adjectives from adverbs and verbs.

Ending	Examples
-able/-ible	comfortable, remarkable, horrible, edible
-al	fictional, educational, logical, national
-ful	bashful, peaceful, helpful, beautiful
-ic	energetic, manic, dramatic, fantastic
-ive	attractive, sensitive, impulsive, persuasive
-less	homeless, careless, endless, useless
-ous	ravenous, mischievous, famous, nervous